

Nale

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“ Justice does not expire. ”

—Nale^[1]

Nale, also known as Nalan'Elin, Nin, or Nakku, is one of the ten Heralds of The Almighty on Roshar, who served as a protector of humanity against the Desolations prior to the Aharietiam.^{[2][3][4]} He's the Herald of Justice and the patron of the Order of Skybreakers, as well as a Skybreaker himself.^{[5][6]}

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Nale



by Karla Ortiz

Family

Relatives [Makibak](#) (Uncle), [Nale's sister](#)

Abilities [Cognitive Shadow](#), [Skybreaker](#), [Shardbearer](#)

Bonded With [121](#)

Titles Herald of the Almighty, Herald of Justice, Patron of the [Skybreakers](#), The Illuminator, The Judge

Aliases Nalan, Nin, Nin-son-God, Darkness, Nakku

Groups [Knights Radiant](#) ([Skybreaker](#))

Homeworld [Ashyn](#)

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Appearance and Personality

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Appearance

Nale is dark-skinned, and often described as looking Makabaki, or more specifically Azish. The most notable aspect of his appearance is a crescent-shaped mark on his right cheek -- something unique to him among the Heralds.^{[7][8]} He's typically dressed in a uniform of an Azish constable: a black coat with a double row of silver buttons and a stiff silver collar poking up from beneath, as well as gloves with long collars of their own.^{[8][9]} His

eyes are mentioned as looking glassy, unfeeling and cold.^{[8][10]} Rosharan artwork typically portrays him as bald, and he does indeed shave his hair close to his scalp.^{[11][12][13]}

Nale has a deep voice, though it is also noted to be "passionless", with no emotion put into his words.^{[14][15]} Similarly, he very rarely emotes with his face, and has even been noted to be able to glare without frowning.^[16]

Personality

Past

“ *The law cannot be moral... But you can be moral as you create laws. Ever must you protect the weakest, those most likely to be taken advantage of.* ”

—Nale^[13]



by Petar Penev

As a younger man, Nale by and large defers to the opinions of his uncle, Makibak, even following him against the singers when Makibak and his "rebels" depart Shinovar.^[17] By the time the Desolations begin in the earnest, however, he has grown into a leader in his own right.^[17] Despite him and Jezrien's factions being ostensibly enemies, he has a rapport with them, one that only grows as they work together. He tends to be straightforward in his speech, accepting things as they are and speaking the truth no matter how others feel about it. He's rather antisocial, and prefers to leave conversations that do not interest him rather than stick around.^[18] However, he does not flee from responsibility, and will take it on willingly.^[19] When he makes a decision, he stands by it, even if he must argue against all other Heralds about it.^[20]

He places great importance on oaths and debts; like many of Makibak's people, he uses a special "ox debt" to signify what he owes to others and what is owed to him, and he will keep the promises implicit in those debts, regardless of circumstances.^[20] His trust, however, is difficult to earn and harder to keep; before swearing in the Oathpact, he admit that he distrusts even Honor.^[19] On the other hand, he is willing to give people second chance, if he believes they are righteous.^[20]

Despite his standoffishness, the Nale of those times is fully capable of emotion and compassion. He is highly aware that law is, by itself, inflexible and immoral, and that it falls on lawmakers to make sure that law protects the weak from the strong.^[13] He believes that there must be checks and balances placed on the people in power, as kings and queens are unable to fully comprehend the plight of the poor under their rulership. To this end, he appreciates having contrarians around, as he is well aware that as a leader, he does not have the necessary experience to understand the common folk.^[20] In battle, Nale is fearless, always standing in defense of the weak, no matter his opposition. He always pays attention to those that are forgotten, and ensures that they, too, are saved.^[21]

Present



by Caio Santos

“ Nale is infuriating. He doesn't actually follow the law—he changes his perceptions, motivations, and even morals at the drop of a sphere. He acts like he's made of iron, but the moment he's confronted with a logical inconsistency, he either changes the conversation or walks away.”

—Kaladin^[16]

Much of Nale's empathy has been worn down, both by the torture in Braize and by his encroaching madness as a Herald.^[22] Over time, Nale no longer trusts his own mind and has lost the confidence in his ability to make the right decisions. He has come to believe that one cannot live by making decisions at every juncture.^[23] This has led him to turn to an idealized image of "the law" as something sacred, and dedicate himself to it no matter how contradictory it may be; at the same time, he can change what the law is to him at when it becomes inconvenient, though it's unclear if he does so consciously.^{[24][25]}

Making the matters worse are the highspren, which encourage the unyielding, literalist interpretation of the law in him, alongside Ishar and his delusions of godhood.^[26] Despite the passage of time, Nale still trusts Ishar and thinks the world of him, believing anything that the man tells him to the point of self-delusion, in all but the most dire of circumstances.^[27] As such, he can be easily convinced to commit even atrocities if he is told it is lawful.^[15]

In his better moments, Nale is aware of what he's lost, and can be horrified by his own behavior, but his current coping patterns quickly reassert themselves.^{[27][28]} He has multiple rationalizations, many of them self-contradictory, yet he refuses to acknowledge that they *are* in conflict with each other, simply switching from one to another as is most convenient to the

current discussion.^[15] He absolutely refuses the idea that the rules he is devoted to can be contradictory or fallible, even when faced with a logical train of thought that proves so.^[29]

Nale is obsessed with order and law, and will go to extreme lengths to ensure he doesn't break any laws of the land he's in.^[22] He is, however, capable of bending the rules to his advantage, such as by appointing himself a lawman to enable him to kill, or pressuring local authorities to change the law.^{[8][30]} This being said, Nale's still focused on obeying the rules, and will punish even his own underlings for breaking them, regardless of whether doing so is to his advantage.^[8] Perhaps because of this, Nightblood wouldn't consider him to be evil.^[31]

In his actions, he seems utterly devoid of mercy, and will execute the maximum penalty available to him without a shred of compassion or leniency, regardless of who his victim is.^[10] He respects those who share his own blind obedience, and will target them as recruits for the Skybreakers.^[9] While understanding that people are fallible, he expects higher standards from those he chooses.^[32] However, he does not inherently dislike those who disagree with him; if the opposing side has a good argument, with proper legal basis, he will accept it without a fuss, and will not hold a grudge over "losing".^[16] His expectations for his enemies are as high as his expectations for his allies, whether in debate or in combat.^[33]

Nale harbors an inherent disdain for Windrunners; although he acknowledges that they are at their best when goaded and protecting others, he also dislikes how spotty their definition of what rules can and can't be obeyed is, and considers their philosophy to be outright anarchist.^{[33][15][29]} He has similarly mixed opinions on the singers; he believes they are the great enemy and mustn't win, yet by the same token sides with them against humanity, believing that singers have the legal precedent as the true rulers of Roshar. To his mind, these two facts are not contradictory.^{[34][22]}

After Kaladin manages to break through his layers of rationalizations and madness, Nale expresses horror and regret at what has become of him, going through a full-on mental breakdown.^[24] Afterwards, he grows somewhat more meek and far more helpful, freely providing information to Szeth and Kaladin, and even trying to oppose Ishar.^{[35][36]} His mental state improves after the connection between him and Ishar is severed, though he is terrified of the prospect of having to go back to Braize.^[37]

Nale seems to have trouble correctly perceiving the passage of time, expressing surprise that food he'd left behind decades prior had gone bad, and believing that events of a millennium ago have only happened only a few centuries prior.^{[6][35]}

Attributes and Abilities

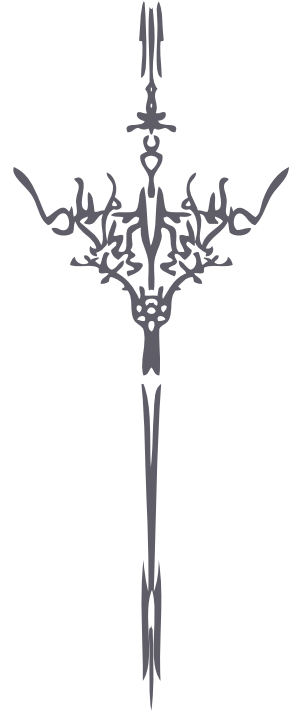
Powers of Honor

“ I WILL GIVE YOU THE POWER TO RESIST
OUR SHARED ENEMY, SHOULD YOU DESIRE
IT. ”

—Honor^[38]

Long before becoming a Herald, Nale has been bestowed command over the Surges directly by Honor.^[38] It's unclear what the exact scope of those powers was, though it seems he was not limited in how many Surges he could use; he was capable of Transportation, and he was quite skilled in its usage even being able to hear the tones of Roshar.^[29] The same powers granted him an excessively long life -- though not truly immortal, he lived almost a thousand years while barely aging.^{[38][39]}

For a more in-depth description of general Heraldic powers, see Herald#Abilities.



by Isaac Stewart

Nalan's glyph

Since the swearing of the Oathpact, Nale has been a Herald of the Almighty. Prior to the creation of Retribution and the subsequent reforging of the Oathpact by the Wind, every death would send him to Braize to be tortured; he could return to Roshar when he wishes to stop the pain, although this causes another Desolation. Within the new Oathpact, however, Nale's mind is held within a vision rather than being aware of his own body and soul, allowing him to ignore the torture.^[37]

Nale is one of the two Heralds, alongside Ishar, to have recovered his Honorblade after Ahariatiam; as such, he retains the ability to use it.^{[6][40]} The Honorblade makes him a Surgebinder, granting him powers over the Surges of Division and Gravitation.^{[8][22]}

Apart from his powers as a Herald, Nale has formed a Nahel bond with the highspren 121, making him a Skybreaker. He's the only Skybreaker in centuries to have reached the Fifth Ideal. This bond also gives him access to a living Shardblade, meaning he has two Blades in total.^{[28][6]} His double bond -- with the Honorblade and the spren -- slightly enhances his powers.^[41] He also has access to living Shardplate, which he can summon and recall at will in an instant, allowing him to perform surprise attacks with it.^[15] While Nale

has had access to Surgebinding during the entire Era of Solitude, he seems to avoid using it in the presence of others, likely to keep a low profile.^[8] This changes after he joins the singers, and he seems to have no issues using Gravitation in combat.^[13] He appears to have a stronger "pull" on Stormlight than regular Knights Radiant; when he breaths it in, it is pulled away from any Radiant attempting to do the same.^[24]

Following his duel with Kaladin and the subsequent breakdown at the Skybreaker monastery in Shinovar, Nale's spren departs.^[24] It is unclear what, if anything, this means for his status as a Knight Radiant, given that 121 reappears after the new Oathpact is put into effect.^[42]

Combat Skills

“ It is rare that I must use the true skills of a Herald against a mortal. We ... do not deploy them frivolously. ”

—Nale^[15]

Nale has over five millennia of combat experience, making him one of the most skilled, deadliest fighters on the planet. When he wishes to, he can perform superhuman feats even without the aid of Stormlight, moving faster, reacting quicker and hitting harder than any mortal man. He is capable of moving so quickly, he appears as a blur, and break apart Shardplate with his bare hands. However, he is reluctant to engage his full strength unless he is convinced that his opponent is a competent enough fighter.^[15]

Nale has two swords, his Honorblade and his Shardblade, though he does not dual-wield them, instead fighting with only one at a time. He seems to have no clear preference for either Blade.^{[13][15]} He is proficient in using his Shardblade both as a sword and as a spear. His combat style is unfamiliar to modern warriors; while it bears some similarity to Windstance, it is more frantic.^[15]

His long history of combat has left him unfazed by wounds of pain; he can take an arrow to the face and react with little more than mild annoyance at being interrupted.^[13]

Legal Knowledge

Nale appears to be well-versed in Rosharan law and legal systems. He can seamlessly operate in various states, especially throughout Western Roshar, and use their laws to his advantage.^[8] Moreover, Nale appears to be the Heralds' expert in lawkeeping and lawmaking. In the ancient times, he was



by botanicaxu

Nale and his Skybreakers

the one to teach Rosharans about establishing a fair and just legal code. Some of his rules are still in effect on Roshar, most notably the Right of Travel, which he prescribed to prevent the abuses of the weak.^[13]

Resources

Nale is the head of the Order of Skybreakers, with many of its members sworn to follow him directly as their Third Ideal. This provides him with a small but powerful force willing to obey his every command. The Skybreakers seem to execute his commands unquestioningly, even when he turns against mankind.^[43] Some of them have sworn the Fourth Ideal, while others are merely squires, though all seem well-trained.^[28]

Apart from the Skybreakers, Nale seems to have vast resources and connections. He has access to various rare items and creatures: he acquired a larkin, has a fabrial able to bring people back from the dead, and was even in possession of Nightblood for a while, having obtained it through unknown means.^{[8][9]} He also has access to an unknown seon.^[44] He keeps caches of food and supplies throughout the continent, though many of them are poorly-maintained.^{[6][35]}

He is well-connected in Western Roshar. He can track the Edgedancer Lift over vast distances and easily get his hands on the attire of local lawkeepers, as well as necessary paperwork for him to join them.^[8] He's also fostered good relationships with most local governments, enough so that they're willing to grant him authority after he reveals himself and the Skybreakers to them.^[45] It's unknown how well he's embedded himself in the structures of Eastern Roshar, although he has acquired the authority to act as a lawkeeper in Alethkar from King Gavilar Kholin.^[46]

History

Early Life

There is no person we would welcome more eagerly into this pact than you. You are the single most honorable man I have ever had the privilege of opposing. ”

—Jezrien to Nale^[13]

“ Nale was originally born on Alaswha, approximately nine hundred years before the calamity that forced humanity to flee the planet for Roshar. He was close with his uncle, Makibak, and had a sister; no other relatives are known.^{[38][47]} Rather than being part of the main empire forged on Alaswha, the three of them lived far from it, across the planet's central sea.^[38]

As a young man, Nale, along with his uncle, was among the emissaries sent by his nation to negotiate with the Rayse-backed empire. As the two were returning home, they were visited by Honor, who offered them the ability to use the Surges to resist the empire's influence.^[38] Unfortunately, nine hundred years later the resulting conflict led to the destruction of Alaswha's ecosystem and atmosphere, and the death of Nale's sister.^[47]



by Marie Seeberger

In the aftermath of the final battle, Makibak was approached by Jezrien, the king of one of the now-fallen empire's member states. Despite being enemies, Jezrien offered Makibak and his people a place among the evacuees fleeing for Roshar. As Makibak accepted, Nale went along with him, finding himself on the new planet.^[47] Unfortunately, within the span of fifty years, Makibak, Nale and their people found the confines of the territory designated for them by the singers to be too restrictive, leading to the group departing the would-be Shinovar and striking out across the mountains. This, in turn, led to rising tensions with Roshar's native population.^[17] Although Jezrien was opposed to this expansion, making him and Nale enemies once more, Nale felt that he was in Jezrien's debt; at some point, he offered him a special ox mark to signify a favor owed.^[39] Eventually, he would also become acquainted with Taln, though the exact circumstances of that meeting are unknown.^[20]

Eventually, the war between singers and humans erupted. During the ensuing forty-three years of conflict, Nale would join Jezrien's side and act as a scout for their forces. However, due to his prior contributions, he was invited to participate in the Oathpact. Despite some initial misgivings, he agreed, and joined in the swearing of the oaths.^{[18][19]} When the time came to select the tenth member of the Oathpact, Nale was the one to suggest Taln, and argued in favour of the man, eventually convincing the others.^[20]

The Desolations

Following the swearing of the Oathpact, Nale became a Herald, returning each time a Desolation broke out to help save people from the calamity. When the Surgebinders began appearing, Nale was initially reluctant to take them under his patronage, even though the nascent Skybreakers named him their master. Following some sort of the disturbance in the toparchy of Revv, however, he agreed to do so, becoming the last Herald to formally accept his Knights Radiant.^[5] Despite this initial reluctance, he eventually ended up bonding a highspren of his own, 121, and joining his own Radiant Order, becoming the only Herald to have done so.^{[6][13][48]} From then on out, 121 would follow him to Braize upon his death.^[34]

Some time after bonding 121, Nale would institute the Right of Travel, which is still present in Rosharan laws as of the True Desolation.^{[13][49]}

Like all other Heralds besides Taln, in time Nale grew too exhausted to keep participating in the Oathpact. He and the others left their Honorblades behind and abandoned the Oathpact in an event later known as Aharietiam, around four and a half thousand years before the True Desolation.^{[50][13]} However, Nale eventually recovered his Blade.^{[6][40]}

Era of Solitude

The False Desolation

At some point shortly before the False Desolation, Nale returned from hiding to lead the Order of Skybreakers. He informed them of the truth about humanity's origins, and how their control over the Surges destroyed Alaswha. From them, this information spread, deepening the rifts between the Radiant Orders at the time; it would eventually be one of the reasons behind the Recreance.^[51]



At the end of the False Desolation and shortly before the Recreance, Nale and Kalak were both active participants in the conflict, witnessing the negotiations between humans and the Regals.^[52] Though he seemingly was not present for the binding of Ba-Ado-Mishram, he witnessed the mental damage the event did to the singers.^[53] While Kalak came to regret this event happening, Nale's opinion on it is unknown.^[54]

The Hunt for Knights Radiant

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“ You might be right. The Desolation may still have arrived. However, I'd have killed you, and been correct to do so—for I believed it was the best course at the time, and was following what I'd been told. ”

—Nale to Kaladin^[15]

Approximately a thousand years before the True Desolation, Nale woke up one day and realized that he had harmed someone out of irritation. The incident scared the already-unstable man, leading him to believe that he could not be trusted with making his own choices. From then on out, Nale would be dedicated wholly to upholding the law, no matter how nonsensical or contradictory it was.^[24]

It was around that time that Nale began to work on preventing another Desolation from happening. Ishar informed him that to do so, he would need to eliminate any nascent Surgebinder who was not part of Nale's own order of Skybreakers, whose bonds he had the capacity to permit and deny.^{[6][15]} By the time of the reunification of Alethkar, Nale was still hunting, having formed a methodology that agreed with his own sentiments: he would track down Surgebinders who had committed some kind of a crime, no matter how minor, and execute them under the pretense of punishment.^[55] Many spren were aware of what he was doing, but were largely indifferent to it, seeing it as spre willing to bond getting what was coming to them.^[56]

Nale would continue to command the Order of Skybreakers over the centuries, transforming them into a secret society as he led them across Roshar in his crusade to eliminate every Surgebinder not of their order.^[57] During that time, he still kept in contact with some of the other Heralds, notably Kalak and Chana. Prior to Chana's marriage to Lin Davar, Nale warned her that it would be a poor idea.^[58] Later, it was Nale who insisted to Chana that her daughter, a budding Lightweaver, would have to be eliminated, starting the chain of events that eventually led to the True Desolation.^[44]

The Assassination of Gavilar Kholin

“ Tonight I found reason to have [Gavilar] killed, but it will take me months of planning to achieve the proper legality. ”

—Nale^[46]

Eventually, Nale got in contact with the Alethi king Gavilar Kholin through Kalak and his Sons of Honor, which the king was a part of. While Nale participated in Gavilar's secret project, he didn't seem to have much patience for it. Regardless, he visited the man the night of his assassination in Tanat 1167.^[59]

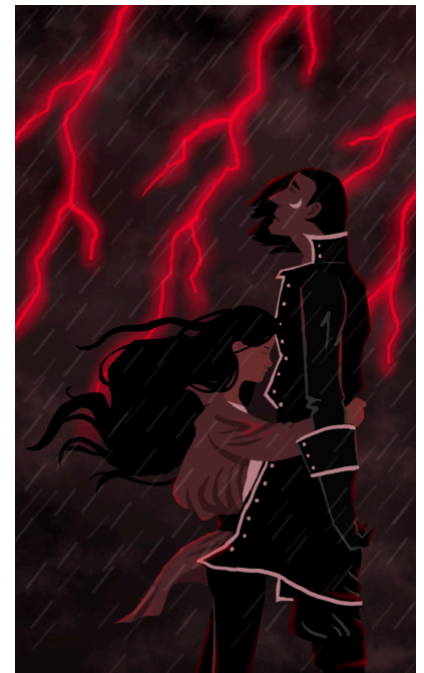
A few hours before the feast began, Nale stumbled upon Venli and Ulim skulking around the Kholinar Palace, and immediately recognized the latter. Silencing the Voidspren, he began questioning Venli about the number of returning Voidspren; however, she managed to trick him into believing that it was his own actions that had prompted a new Return. Incensed, and thinking that Gavilar's project caused the Voidspren to come back, Nale decided to try and prevent further catastrophe. He explained to Venli that there was a loophole in the treaty that would allow the listeners to attack the Alethi if they believed there was a conspiracy against them. He also pointed her towards Szeth and pardoned her for sneaking into the off-limits section of the palace before leaving in a huff.^[46]

During the feast, Nale, once more accompanied by Kalak, met with Gavilar to discuss the king's progress. When the Queen Navani Kholin walked into the room to question Gavilar's absence from the feast, Nale took it as an opportunity to take his leave and dragged Kalak along, perhaps still furious with what Venli had told him.^[59] The same night, the two of them briefly spoke with Elhokar Kholin, then left the feasting hall and stumbled on Jasnah Kholin, whom Nale treated rather coldly before moving on.^{[60][61]}

Encounters with Lift

Following the feast, Nale continued his trail of murder, killing the Truthwatcher Ym for a forty-year-old crime.^{[55][62]} Afterwards, he focused his efforts on the Edgedancer Lift, tracking her down all the way to the royal palace of Azimir. While he managed to catch her, and fill out the proper paperwork to have her killed, Gawx died in the process and Lift managed to heal the boy. This led to Gawx being pronounced the new Prime Aqasix and pardoning Lift, which in turn forced Nale to relent, as he had no excuse to kill her anymore.^[8]

Nale briefly returned East for the Battle of Narak, where he caught and revived recently-killed Szeth in Ishishach 1173.^{[63][9]} He proceeded to recruit the Shin and gave him Nightblood, which he had acquired at an unknown point in the past.^[9] Afterwards, he took Szeth with him back West on another hunt, this time to Yeddaw, to track down yet another budding Surgebinder.^[64] In Jeses 1174 he successfully found the Truthwatcher Arshqqam, but before he could kill her, Lift



by LittleGreyDragon
Lift hugging Nale in the
Everstorm

confronted him just as the Everstorm was approaching. The combination of the storm and Lift's words managed to get through to Nale as he realized that his plan had failed, and that he had killed for nothing.^[27]

True Desolation

Joining the Singers

Following the appearance of the Everstorm, Nale had a minor breakdown, leaving for parts unknown for several weeks before coming back for Szeth, dropping him off at the Skybreaker training grounds, then leaving again to seek Ishar's guidance.^[28] Whatever Ishar had told him worked well to calm Nale down, enough so that he was back to his confident self when he returned.^[65]

He took all the Skybreakers with him south, to Marat. There, he told them the truth of Aharietiam and the origins of the Desolations.^[6] Afterwards, they went further, to Thaylen City, though only Nale and Szeth were present during the Battle of Thaylen Field in Nanab 1174.^{[66][67]} As they watched, Nale informed Szeth that he intended for the Skybreakers to follow the singers, as they were the original owners of Roshar.^[66] However, he did not participate in the battle.^[23]

Initially, Nale attempted to convince Szeth to do the same.^[43] When Szeth chose to follow Dalinar Kholin instead, Nale had no hard feelings about it, and promised to return later to teach Szeth the Surge of Division. He then departed, though it's uncertain where to.^[22]

The Emuli Frontline

“ *How are you a Bondsmith? You should not exist, Blackthorn. Your cause is not righteous. You should be denied the true Surges of Honor.* ”

—Nale to Dalinar^[13]

A year into the True Desolation, in early 1175, Nale and his Skybreakers were sent to Emul to fight on the side of the Voidbringers. During one particular battle, he approached the army leader, Dalinar, and tried to persuade him to submit to the law of the singers; however, before he could go too far into his speech, Cord shot him in the face, to which he barely responded. After pulling the arrow out and healing his face, he descended to the deck of the floating platform the others were on.^[13]

Nale approached Dalinar, incredulous that the man such as him would be made a Bondsmith. He tried to amend this and launched himself at Dalinar, but before he could attack, Dalinar, prompted by Stormfather, used his abilities on the Herald, and saw a number of visions from Nale's memory.

Starting from Nale abandoning the Oathpact, they went back in time, showing Nale fighting dark forces while protecting a small child, Nale establishing the Vorin Right of Travel, Nale kneeling before a highspren, and endless fighting he partook in. Last was the vision of Nale agreeing to join the Oathpact with Jezrien.^[13]

When the visions ended, Nale, shocked at what had happened, backed away from Dalinar, revealing a line connecting the two -- the manifestation of the Oathpact. Tearing the line, Nale quickly leaped out of the platform and fled, clearly terrified by Dalinar's feat.^[13]

The Shinovar Crusade

“ I hear you've been offering my disciple radical philosophy, Windrunner. I should like to hear it for myself. ”

—Nale to Kaladin^[29]

When Kaladin and Szeth departed for Shinovar to resolve the mystery of its silence and carry out Szeth's crusade, Nale was initially absent; however, he would arrive upon learning that under Kaladin's influence, Szeth was straying from the path of a "true" Skybreaker.^[14] His arrival led Szeth to start behaving more cautiously, backtracking on the progress he had made with Kaladin. During the initial leg of their joint journey, Nale engaged Kaladin in a debate over the importance of law, and whether it needed to be upheld at all times -- a discussion left ultimately with no clear winner, though with Nale convinced that he had won.^[29]



by Esther Schrader

Nale oversaw Szeth's trial at the Lightweaver monastery; he attempted to insist that rules were broken when Kaladin and Syl assisted, but relented without argument when Szeth pointed out that there were no rules to the trials.^[16] Kaladin later attempted to bond with Nale and help him, to little initial effect. As the two continued to argue about the importance of law, however, Kaladin managed to get Nale to talk about his early days as Herald, leading to the beginnings of a mental breakthrough in the man.^[68] However, Nale would still oversee Szeth's next trial, the fight against Elid at the Dustbringer monastery, where he explained that while he fights alongside singers because that is what the law demands, he does not actually want them to win.^[34]

When the time came to visit the Skybreaker monastery, Nale, as the bearer of the order's Honorblade, left ahead of time to prepare Szeth's trial.^[69] Rather than fight Szeth, he only demanded his obedience. When Szeth refused to do so without getting his answers first, Nale attempted to coerce him to accept, eventually attacking when it became obvious Szeth would not submit. However, rather than Szeth, he wound up fighting Kaladin, whom Szeth appointed as his champion.^[33] During the exchange of blows between the two, Kaladin and Nale started debating once more, slowly breaking through Nale's various rationalizations of his behavior. However, this was insufficient, and Nale defeated Kaladin, breaking his bones and destroying Kaladin's flute.^{[15][24]} However, thanks to Kaladin's earlier practice, the Wind managed to play the melody back, distracting Nale enough for Kaladin to retell the tale of the Wandersail and truly get through to Nale. Nale still attempted to resist, going as far as taking Szeth hostage. When Kaladin pointed out how abhorrent that was, Nale eventually broke down, admitting that he needed psychological help.^[24]

Confronting Ishar and the New Oathpact

“ *I want to be better. I want to be that man, the one who stood against the law to defend those who deserved mercy. That is the only path to true justice.* ”

—Nale^[70]

Following his breakdown at the end of his confrontation with Kaladin, Szeth, and Syl, Nale revealed to them that the force possessing Shinovar was Ishar, rather than an Unmade, and promised to assist them in confronting the other mad Herald.^[70] As the group travelled to the Bondsmith monastery, Nale explained Ishar's connection to the power of Odium and told them that the monastery was located at the site of the Ahariatiam.^[35]

After the group met with Ishar, the other Herald expressed disappointment with Nale, promising to replace him after initiating Szeth as a replacement for Jezrien. Despite being an Honorbearer, Nale did not participate in Szeth's final trial -- the group beatdown of the younger man.^[71] Instead, he stood off to the side, and attempted to assist Kaladin's attempts to reach Ishar and break him out of his madness.^{[72][73]} However, this attempt too ended in failure and eventually, Ishar returned the pain he'd been holding back from Nale to him. Nale collapsed, unable to bear the weight of all his actions amplified by the power of Odium.^{[36][74]} It was not until Kaladin used Nightblood to sever the connections between Ishar and the others that Nale was able to stand up again.^[75]

Following the confrontation with Ishar, and the resulting incident with Nightblood, Nale's connection to the other Herald -- and through him, to Odium -- was severed; however, it was at this point that Retribution was born, and began recalling the power of Honor, which would include the

Cognitive Shadows of the Heralds. Nale was ready to embrace the end, but then the Wind asked him to reforge the Oathpact. Despite his initial terror at the thought, upon learning that torture would not be part of the new system, Nale agreed. He assisted Ishar with setting up the Honorblades, and when the time came, participated in swearing Kaladin in as the new tenth member of the Heralds.^[37] As such, when the new Oathpact came into effect, he disappeared along with the others.^[76]

Relationships

Other Heralds

Jezrien



by Katie Payne

With the other Heralds when they abandoned their Honorblades

“ *King of Heralds, and Herald of Kings. My enemy, then my dear friend.* ”

—Nale on Jezrien^[29]

Back on Alaswha, it's Jezrien who finds Nale and Makibak and offers them and their people the opportunity to go with them to the relative safety of Roshar.^[47] After some generations, the two become enemies once more as Nale pushes to expand past Shinovar. Nevertheless, Nale still respects Jezrien deeply and believes he owes him a debt, represented by an ox mark. Jezrien, in turn, considers Nale the most honorable man he's ever known.^[39] Later, Jezrien frees Nale from his debt and encourages him to join the Oathpact. The two maintain a sense of deep respect towards each other.^[18] Nale considers him a dear friend, and believes working alongside him to be a great honor.^{[29][13]}

After the Ahariatiam, Nale's respect for Jezrien erodes severely as their respective madnesses set in. By the time of the True Desolation, Nale considers him little more than a drooling idiot.^[8] Nevertheless, he is still

stunned by his death whenever he thinks about it.^[24]

Taln

“ *He deserves a second chance. It will be good for us to have someone who is not a king among us.* ”

—Nale about Taln^[20]

Before becoming a Herald, Nale had apparently met and befriended Taln, enough so for the two to be cordial with one another and for Taln to be aware of Nale's distaste for Surgebinding. When the time comes to select the tenth Herald, Nale is the one to recommend Taln, and insists on it despite the wariness of others. He claims that Taln deserves a second chance after his attempt to assassinate Cultivation, and that it is necessary for their group to have both a contrarian and someone who represents the perspective of ordinary mortals. He is also the one to convince Taln to join, promising him that with his newfound power, Taln can help solve the problems he sees in the human society of the time.^[20]

Though he leaves Taln along with the others at Aharietiam, Nale apparently continues to have faith in him, believing that the man would never have broken.^[46] However, it is not until after his confrontation with Kaladin that Nale acknowledges that he has betrayed Taln. He is both extremely guilty, and extremely impressed with Taln's perseverance.^[35]

Ishar

“ *You are weak, Nale. I will replace you next.* ”

—Ishar^[71]

Nale greatly respects Ishar and his opinions, considering the Herald of Luck to be the wisest above them.^[6] It was at Ishar's suggestion that Nale began his crusade against Surgebinders, and when the Everstorm comes, Nale goes to Ishar for comfort and advice.^{[15][6]} This respect extends somewhat to the Bondsmiths in general, as he has extremely high standards for what makes one worthy of the bond -- standards Ishar meets, but Dalinar doesn't.^[13] Even after waking up and realizing how wrong Ishar is, Nale remains respectful towards him.

By contrast, Ishar, in throes of madness, considers Nale to be little more than a somewhat useful tool. Part of the reason he began his work on the Shin Honorbearers was his dissatisfaction with Nale's handling of the dissidents

within the Skybreakers.^{[70][36]} He has no qualms about harming Nale, whether by threatening to replace him or by burdening him with an amplified, debilitating sense of guilt.^[72]

Kalak

“ *You're worried about everything. (...) Shut up.* ”

—Nale to Kalak^[60]

There is no indication that Kalak and Nale are particularly close during the Desolations, although Nale does ask after him when the Heralds gather for the Aharietiam.^[77] Afterwards, however, Nale and Kalak do travel together a couple of times. They are both present for the False Desolation, where they bear witness to the failed parley between humans and singers and the capture of Ba-Ado-Mishram.^{[53][52]} Nale also comes to Kholinar on the night of the assassination of Gavilar, seemingly at Kalak's urging, though he does not stay long.^[78]

Nale has little patience for Kalak and his worries, and his perpetual paranoia and fear annoys him. When Kalak expresses his concerns about Shalash, Nale dismisses him outright, and when Kalak tries to convince him that Gavilar's research is their ticket off the planet, Nale does not bother to feign interest.^{[60][78]}

Chana

“ *You're being unreasonable. This entire endeavor of yours was unreasonable.* ”

—Nale to Chana^[44]

It appears that Nale and Chana have kept somewhat in touch following the Aharietiam; before Chana marries Lin Davar, Nale warns her that this was a terrible idea.^[58] He is overall unimpressed with Chana's newfound commitment to married life, and does not consider it to be genuine.^[44] When it turns out that her own daughter has become a Surgebinder, it is Nale who informs Chana that she must kill Shallan, or he will have one of his Skybreakers do it. He has some degree of authority over her, as he phrases this as an order rather than a suggestion.^[44]

Szeth

“ *Szeth-son-Neturo, I watched you keep your word with perfection. This is a thing lost to most people—it is the only genuine beauty in the world. I doubt I* ”

have ever found a man more worthy of the Skybreakers than you. ”

—Nale to Szeth^[9]

Nale is very impressed with Szeth's dedication to the law, calling him one of the people most deserving of joining the Skybreakers. He's been watching Szeth for a considerable period of time while the latter was Truthless, having followed him since shortly prior to the assassination of Gavilar Kholin.^[46] He greatly respects Szeth's obedience to the Oathstone, enough so to revive him from death and entrust him with Nightblood.^[9]

Even after recruiting Szeth, Nale seems to take a special interest in him above other candidates. He seems comfortable telling Szeth his life story and speaking to him in private about the true history of the world.^{[6][22]} He's also fairly indifferent and accepting of Szeth's opinions, despite them disagreeing with his own.^[79] Even when Szeth decides to side with the people opposing singers -- and, by extension, against Nale -- the Herald respects it and remains friendly, even promising to teach him further.^[22]

When Szeth appears to stray from the path of a Skybreaker, Nale returns to mentor him, and ensure he is not corrupted by Kaladin's "radical philosophy".^[14] He argues relentlessly with Kaladin, hoping to keep his protege on the "right path".^[29] However, he still treats Szeth fairly, even when the man begins to defy him, so long as this defiance is within the rules.^[16] By contrast, Szeth begins to buckle under Nale's strict command as he starts to see his own value. Initially, this manifests as minor disagreements, and deliberately doing things in contrary ways.^[21] Eventually, he openly refuses to merely blindly follow Nale's commands unless he gets an explanation for them. This is what eventually gets Nale to attack him, although he remains respectful throughout, agreeing to Szeth selecting Kaladin as his champion.^[33]

After the confrontation at the Skybreaker monastery, Nale refuses to harm Szeth, and refrains from participating in the beatdown that Ishar organizes as his "final test".^[72]

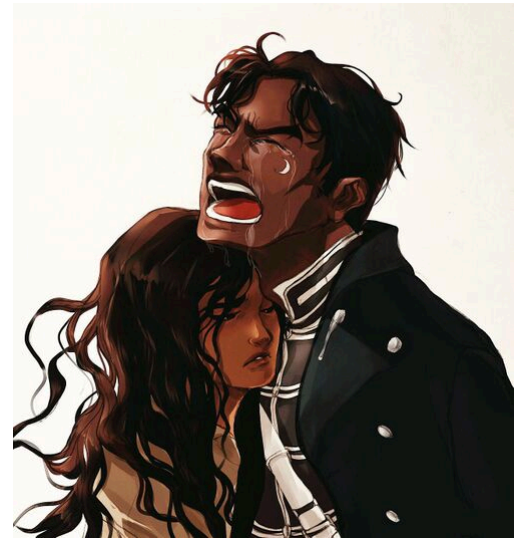
Lift

Something about that child ... always outside my reach, taunting me with who I used to be... ”

—Nale on Lift^[68]

Nale has been hunting Lift relentlessly for a while by the time she arrives in Azimir and attempts to rob the Bronze Palace, enough so for her to recognize him right away. She nicknames him Darkness, and is initially terrified of him, though when his plans to kill her fail, he departs easily enough.^[8]

“ Afterwards, Lift takes to hunting him herself, trying to stop him from killing more Surgebinders, which eventually leads to the two having a confrontation in Yeddaw. Nale is initially rather glad that she came to be judged, and has every intention of killing her. However, she manages to talk him down and point out to him that a Desolation is starting again, which seems to temporarily return him to his senses. She even hugs him, although he departs shortly after.^[27]



by botanicaxu

Lift hugging Nale in Yeddaw

Although Nale soon returns to his usual law-obsessed self, the encounter with Lift sticks with him, and he reminisces about it occasionally. It appears that remembering Lift brings back his own, long-buried sense of true justice. He considers her to be the only person to have ever defeated him in single combat, albeit through unconventional means, and wishes to meet with her again, hoping she would help him remember what he used to be like.^{[68][15]}

Ulim

“ We are not friends. You persist only because I cannot destroy spren. ”

—Nale to Ulim^[46]

Nale and Ulim are familiar with each other, and have interacted in the past enough for Nale to recognize the Voidspren on sight. Nale despises him; he brushes away Ulim's attempts at small talk and tells him that if he had the capacity to kill Voidspren, Ulim would already be dead. In turn, despite being immune to anything Nale could throw at him, Ulim is terrified of him, and immediately falls silent when commanded. After realizing how badly time has ravaged his mind, Ulim notes that the Herald's condition is similar to that of the Fused, and revels in Venli tricking him.^[46]

Kaladin

“ The true goal of every revolutionary. To tear down, rip apart, and destroy. You have no philosophy to cherish, therefore you seek to ruin others', jealous that they have answers. ”

—Nale to Kaladin^[29]

Upon first meeting Kaladin, Nale is immediately hostile towards him, believing him to be corrupting Szeth. The two argue over what is law and whether one should follow it unquestioningly, with Nale in favour and Kaladin against, although Nale's madness and greater experience make him a difficult debate opponent.^[29] Kaladin, in turn, feels the obligation to help Nale in his newfound capacity as a therapist. However, he is resentful of the idea, and only attempts so because he feels like he has to, rather than because he wants to.^[21]

Kaladin sees some progress when he manages to remind Nale of his past as a hero of the people, although his overeagerness causes Nale to withdraw again.^[68] Eventually, the two clash in the Skybreaker monastery, with Kaladin fighting on behalf of Szeth to prevent him from being forced to submit to Nale. Kaladin sees this as a way to help Szeth; Nale sees the fight as a way to free his protege from the Windrunner's influence.^[33] Eventually, with the help of Wind, Kaladin manages to get through to Nale, not by fighting, but by retelling the story of the *Wandersail*, reminding Nale of his past and showing him how far he'd fallen.^[24] Afterwards, Nale becomes more polite and friendly towards Kaladin.^[37]

121

121 is Nale's bonded spren, providing him with Skybreaker powers alongside his Honorblade.^[21] The exact relation between them, and how the two have come to meet and bond, is unknown. However, 121 would always go to Braize alongside Nale when the time came to seal them, and thus would presumably suffer from the same torture that was inflicted on Nale.^[80]

When Nale breaks down in the Skybreaker monastery, 121 flees.^[24] When the new Oathpact is sealed, 121 appears within the vision with the other Heralds, suggesting the two remain bonded.^[42]

Family

Nale is known to have had an uncle, Makibak, and an unnamed sister.^[47] When young, he seems to respect Makibak as his senior, asking for his opinion and following in his footsteps, even going so far as opposing the singers as part of a "rebel" force.^{[38][17]} His relationship with his sister is unknown; she dies during the destruction of Ashyn and he is devastated when he finds her corpse, screaming and cradling it.^[47]

Culture

Nin-son-God, Nale, Nakku, Nalan—this man had a hundred different names and was revered across all Roshar. ”

As a Herald, Nale is significant in a number of Rosharan cultures. In Vorinism, he's called **Nalan**, and is associated with the number 2 (or Nan), the Essence of Vapor, and the attributes Just and Confident.^[81] People often swear by Nalan's hand, or say "Nalan send..." to express hope.^{[82][9]} More crudely, an expression "Nale's nuts" is sometimes used.^[83] On the whole, however, he does not feature in Vorin sayings particularly often; he's certainly less present there than Kalak.



by Isaac Stewart

In Shinovar, he's revered as **Nin-son-God**, and believed to be a founder of humanity.^[65] Like all Heralds, he has his own monastery, near the country's eastern border.^[33] The Azish know him as **Nakku the Judge**.^[84] He's also ascribed the title of the Illuminator, and is said to wield the Sword of Retribution.^{[9][85]} He is mentioned as having a hundred other names across the world, among them the Herald of Justice.^[65]

Trivia

- Nale's portrait used in the chapter arches is called the Judge by the Dragonsteel Entertainment staff.^[86]

Notes

1. *Words of Radiance* interlude I-2
2. *Prelude to the Stormlight Archive*
3. *Rhythm of War* chapter 14
4. *Rhythm of War* chapter 76
5. *Words of Radiance* chapter 43 epigraph
6. *Oathbringer* chapter 106
7. *Oathbringer* Chicago signing
— Arcanum - 2017-11-21
8. *Words of Radiance* interlude I-9
9. *Words of Radiance* chapter 88
10. *Edgedancer* chapter 8
11. *Nale* chapter capstone
12. *Nale* relief
13. *Rhythm of War* chapter 47
14. *Wind and Truth* chapter 66
15. *Wind and Truth* chapter 109
16. *Wind and Truth* chapter 72
17. *Wind and Truth* chapter 55
18. *Wind and Truth* chapter 62

19. [Wind and Truth chapter 64](#)
20. [Wind and Truth chapter 65](#)
21. [Wind and Truth chapter 86](#)
22. [Oathbringer chapter 121](#)
23. [Oathbringer chapter 120](#)
24. [Wind and Truth chapter 110](#)
25. [Wind and Truth chapter 27](#)
26. [San Diego Comic-Con@Home 2020](#)
— [Arcanum](#) - 2020-07-23
27. [Edgedancer chapter 19](#)
28. [Oathbringer chapter 90](#)
29. [Wind and Truth chapter 69](#)
30. [Edgedancer chapter 16](#)
31. [Orem Signing](#)
— [Arcanum](#) - 2019-03-16
32. [Stormlight Three Update #5](#)
— [Arcanum](#) - 2016-11-19
33. [Wind and Truth chapter 108](#)
34. [Wind and Truth chapter 90](#)
35. [Wind and Truth chapter 129](#)
36. [Wind and Truth chapter 135](#)
37. [Wind and Truth chapter 144](#)
38. [Wind and Truth chapter 104](#)
39. [Wind and Truth chapter 58](#)
40. [Rhythm of War chapter 111](#)
41. [Words of Radiance Houston signing](#)
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42. [Postlude to the Stormlight Archive](#)
43. [Oathbringer chapter 117](#)
44. [Wind and Truth chapter 93](#)
45. [Oathbringer chapter 92](#)
46. [Rhythm of War chapter 77](#)
47. [Wind and Truth chapter 107](#)
48. [Orem Signing](#)
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49. [Words of Radiance chapter 83](#)
50. [The Way of Kings chapter prelude](#)
51. [Wind and Truth chapter 80](#)
52. [Wind and Truth chapter 85](#)
53. [Rhythm of War chapter 24](#)
54. [Rhythm of War chapter 96 epigraph](#)
55. [Words of Radiance interlude I-2](#)
56. [YouTube Spoiler Stream 3](#)
— [Arcanum](#) - 2021-12-16
57. [Oathbringer chapter 40](#)

58. [Wind and Truth](#) chapter 99
59. [Rhythm of War](#) prologue
60. [Words of Radiance](#) prologue
61. [The Way of Kings](#) prologue
62. [Arcanum Unbounded](#) signing Hoboken
— [Arcanum](#) - 2016-12-03
63. [Words of Radiance](#) chapter 79
64. [Edgedancer](#) chapter 15
65. [Oathbringer](#) chapter 98
66. [Oathbringer](#) chapter 116
67. [Brandon's Blog](#) 2017
— [Arcanum](#) - 2017-10-27
68. [Wind and Truth](#) chapter 89
69. [Wind and Truth](#) chapter 103
70. [Wind and Truth](#) chapter 119
71. [Wind and Truth](#) chapter 130
72. [Wind and Truth](#) chapter 131
73. [Wind and Truth](#) chapter 132
74. [Wind and Truth](#) chapter 138
75. [Wind and Truth](#) chapter 140
76. [Wind and Truth](#) chapter 145
77. [Wind and Truth](#) chapter 77
78. [Wind and Truth](#) prologue
79. [Edgedancer](#) chapter 9
80. [Wind and Truth](#) chapter 95
81. [The Way of Kings](#) Ars Arcanum
82. [Words of Radiance](#) chapter 44
83. [Rhythm of War](#) chapter 7
84. [Oathbringer](#) chapter 53
85. [The Way of Kings](#) chapter 18
86. [Miscellaneous](#) 2020
— [Arcanum](#) - 2020-08-04

This page is probably complete!

*This page contains most of the knowledge we have
on the subject at this time.*

It has yet to be reviewed.

The Stormlight Archive (Roshar)

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([Edgedancer](#) · [Dawnshard](#))

Major Characters

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[Renarin](#) · [Jasnah](#) · [Navani](#) · [Lift](#) · [Moash](#) · [Taravangian](#) · [Taln](#)

Spren

[Syl](#) · [Pattern](#) · [Wyndle](#) · [Glys](#) · [Ivory](#) · [Timbre](#) · [Mayalaran](#) ·
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Knights Radiant

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Voidbringers

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<u>Magic</u>	<u>Highstorms</u> · <u>Everstorm</u> · <u>Lights (Stormlight · Voidlight)</u> · <u>Surgebinding</u> · <u>Voidbinding</u> · <u>Fabrials</u> · <u>Shardblades</u> · <u>Shardplate</u> · <u>Oathgate</u> · <u>Old Magic</u> · <u>Dawnshard</u>
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